



Health & Wellness

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INTRODUCTION

Project Background

Social media has become one of the main spaces where Gen Z expresses identity, lifestyle, and personal values. Among the many forms of digital self-presentation, wellness content has emerged as a dominant trend across platforms such as Instagram and TikTok. Posts related to fitness, self-care, mental health, productivity, healthy eating, and “balanced lifestyles” are often presented through visually curated aesthetics and aspirational narratives.

While wellness content can encourage healthy habits and positive routines, growing concerns suggest that these online performances may not always reflect genuine wellbeing. Instead, wellness may increasingly function as a socially desirable identity shaped by visibility, validation, and audience engagement. Likes, comments, and platform culture can influence how wellness is portrayed, causing health and self-care to become performative rather than internally motivated experiences.

Existing research suggests that social media encourages users to curate idealized versions of themselves that align with socially appealing narratives. However, there is still limited understanding of how authentic digital wellness culture truly is, particularly among Gen Z users who both consume and produce this content daily. The gap between online representation and real-life wellbeing raises important questions about authenticity, identity construction, and the influence of social validation on wellness behaviors.

This project investigates how Gen Z engages with wellness content online and examines whether these behaviors are rooted in genuine self-care practices or shaped by external validation and social expectations. By exploring the relationship between curated digital identities and real-life wellbeing, this research aims to contribute to broader discussions surrounding authenticity, mental health, self-presentation, and contemporary wellness culture in digital environments.

Research Purpose

The purpose of this study is to explore how Gen Z represents and interprets wellness on social media platforms such as Instagram and TikTok. This research seeks to understand the relationship between curated online wellness identities and participants’ actual wellbeing practices in everyday life.

The study specifically investigates whether wellness-related behaviors and content are motivated by genuine desires for self-care and personal wellbeing or by external validation, social approval, and performative online culture. Through surveys, interviews, cultural probes, and content analysis, this project aims to identify patterns in behavior, perception, and motivation related to digital wellness engagement.

Ultimately, this research aims to critically examine the authenticity of online wellness culture and better understand how social media shapes perceptions of health, productivity, self-worth, and identity among Gen Z users.

This research directly aligns with Sustainable Development Goal 3: Good Health and Well Being by examining how digital environments influence Gen Z’s understanding and pursuit of health. While SDG 3 emphasizes promoting genuine physical, mental, and emotional wellbeing, this study questions whether social media’s wellness culture truly supports those goals or distorts them through performative behaviors driven by validation and visibility. By investigating the gap between curated wellness identities and authentic self care practices, this research highlights the growing impact of digital culture on mental health, self perception, and access to meaningful wellbeing. Understanding these dynamics is essential to fostering healthier, more honest approaches to wellness that support long term wellbeing both online and offline.

Top Insights



- Approximately 75% of participants described wellness content as highly curated, aesthetic-driven, or performative rather than fully authentic
- Many Gen Z users experience tension between practicing wellness for personal wellbeing and performing wellness for social validation or online image management.
- Around two-thirds of participants said wellness content can function both as motivation for healthy habits and as a source of pressure, comparison, guilt, or unrealistic expectations.
- Approximately 80% of participants said they trust wellness content more when it feels relatable, practical, emotionally honest, and realistic rather than overly polished or influencer-driven.
- Nearly 70% of participants identified a noticeable gap between their real-life emotions, routines, or struggles and the idealized “vibe” presented in wellness-related posts.
- More than half of participants associated wellness with productivity, discipline, aesthetics, or social desirability rather than purely internal wellbeing.
- Social media engagement metrics such as likes, comments, saves, and views frequently influence how wellness behaviors are shared, perceived, and valued online.
- Digital wellness culture often blurs the boundary between authentic self-care and self-branding practices on social media.

Research Methods

Visual & Content Analysis

Analyze wellness-related Instagram and TikTok posts to identify recurring visual aesthetics, behaviors, themes, and performative markers commonly associated with digital wellness culture.

User Surveys

Conduct surveys to measure how Gen Z users consume, engage with, and are influenced by wellness content in their daily social media experiences.

In-depth Interviews

Interviewed 40 participants to explore participants’ motivations, emotions, and personal experiences related to wellness content, authenticity, and online self-presentation.

Behavioral & Interaction Analysis

Examine how users interact with wellness content and evaluate whether online wellness trends inspire genuine self-care behaviors or contribute to pressure and curated identity maintenance.

Cultural Probe Activities

Ask participants to document their real-time interactions with wellness-related content through screenshots, written reflections, and activity logs to capture authentic reactions and everyday experiences.

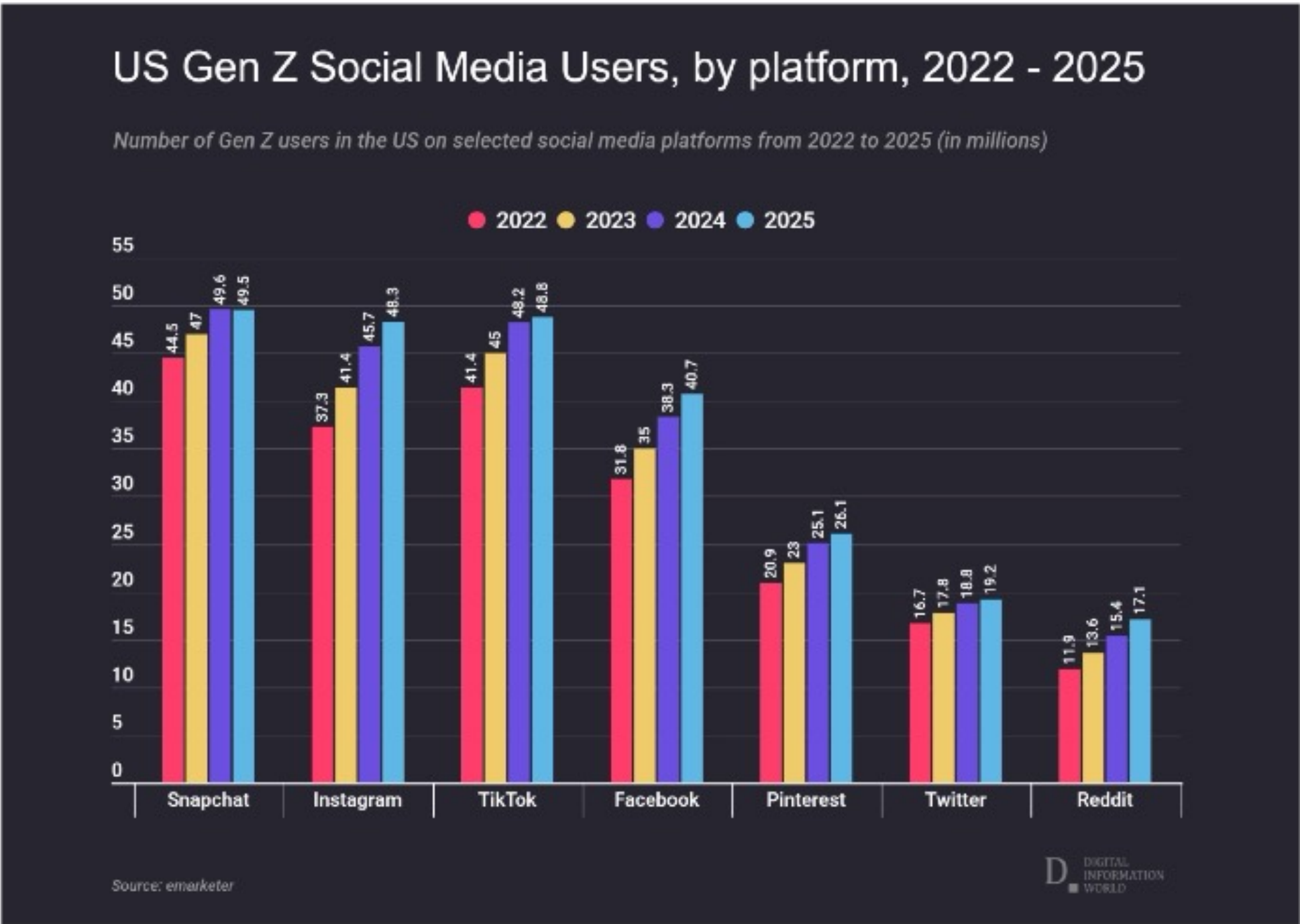
Secondary Research

Review existing literature and cultural discussions related to wellness culture, social media behavior, identity construction, performative behavior, and mental health to contextualize primary research findings.

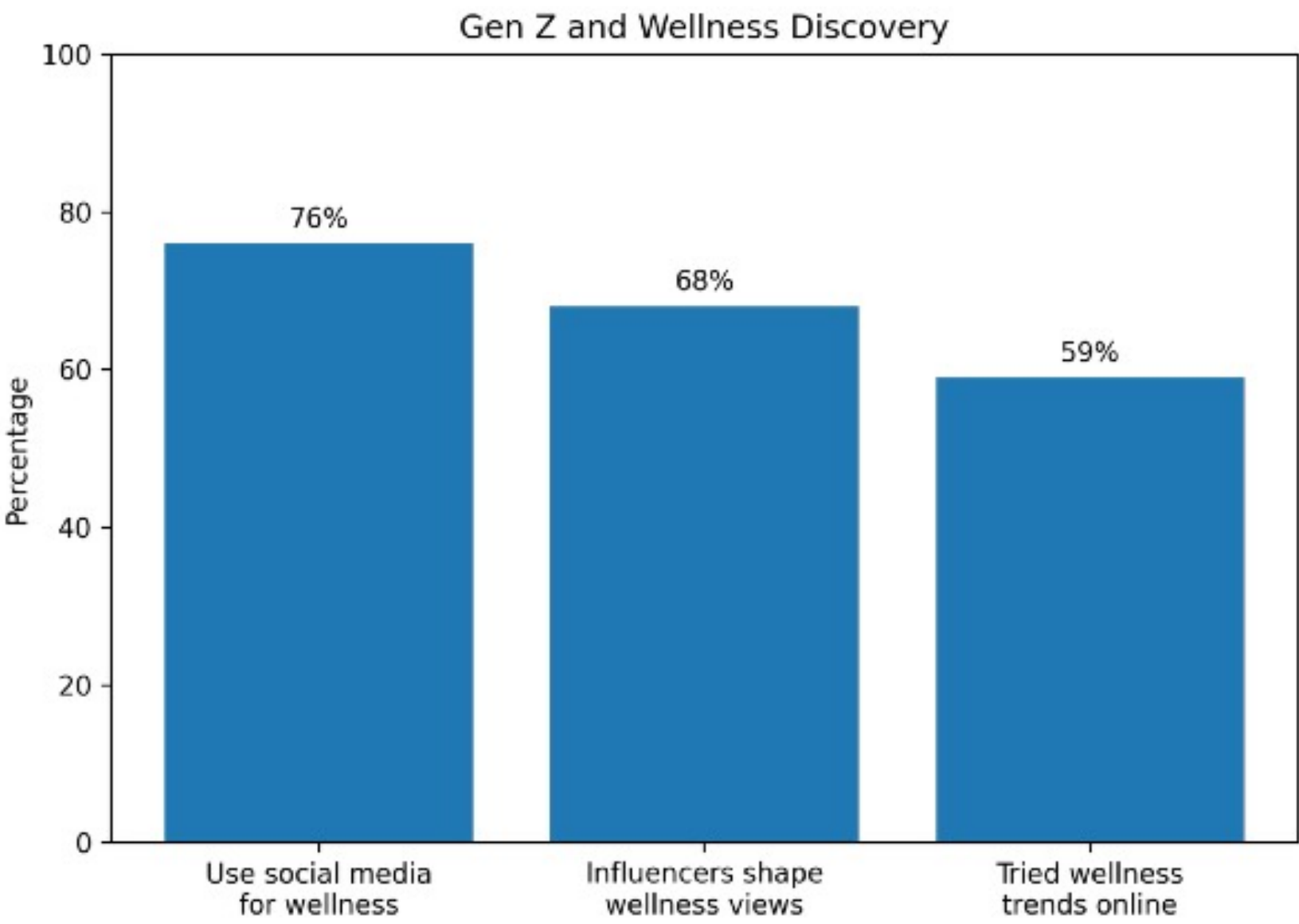
Secondary Research

As the first generation to grow up entirely alongside social media, Gen Z experiences wellness differently than previous generations. Platforms such as Instagram and TikTok have become primary destinations for discovering health advice, fitness routines, self care practices, and lifestyle inspiration. Research shows that 76% of Gen Z use social media to seek wellness related information, while 68% report that influencers shape their understanding of what a healthy lifestyle looks like. Wellness is no longer confined to personal routines. It has become a highly visible and shareable aspect of identity that is continuously shaped by digital culture.

However, this visibility creates a tension between practicing wellness and performing wellness. Studies found that 72% of Gen Z believe social media encourages users to present unrealistic versions of their lives, while 64% feel pressure to appear productive, healthy, or successful online. Additionally, 61% report comparing their wellness habits to those of the people they follow. Rather than functioning solely as a tool for self improvement, social media can transform wellness into a form of social currency where healthy behaviors become content and personal progress becomes something to be displayed, validated, and measured through engagement.



The effects of this dynamic extend beyond perception and into wellbeing itself. Nearly half of Gen Z, 46%, report that social media sometimes makes them feel worse about themselves, while 57% say the constant stream of self improvement content can feel overwhelming. At the same time, 70% believe that taking breaks from social media positively impacts their mental health. Despite these challenges, Gen Z continues to express a desire for more authentic representations of wellness. Research found that 81% prefer content that feels honest and realistic rather than highly curated, while 74% value transparency about struggles and setbacks. Together, these findings suggest that young adults are not rejecting wellness itself, but rather questioning the performative expectations that increasingly surround it online. This tension between authentic wellbeing and public validation became the foundation for our primary research investigation.



Ideal Experience Framework

Built from direct user insights, this framework answers one central question: “My ideal experience with authentic wellness on social media...” By structuring participant data into progressive layers, the framework reveals how specific platform qualities influence practical outcomes, which then shape deeper emotional experiences. This layered system allows us to understand not just what users want from wellness content, but how those ***desires connect to their broader sense of wellbeing and identity.***

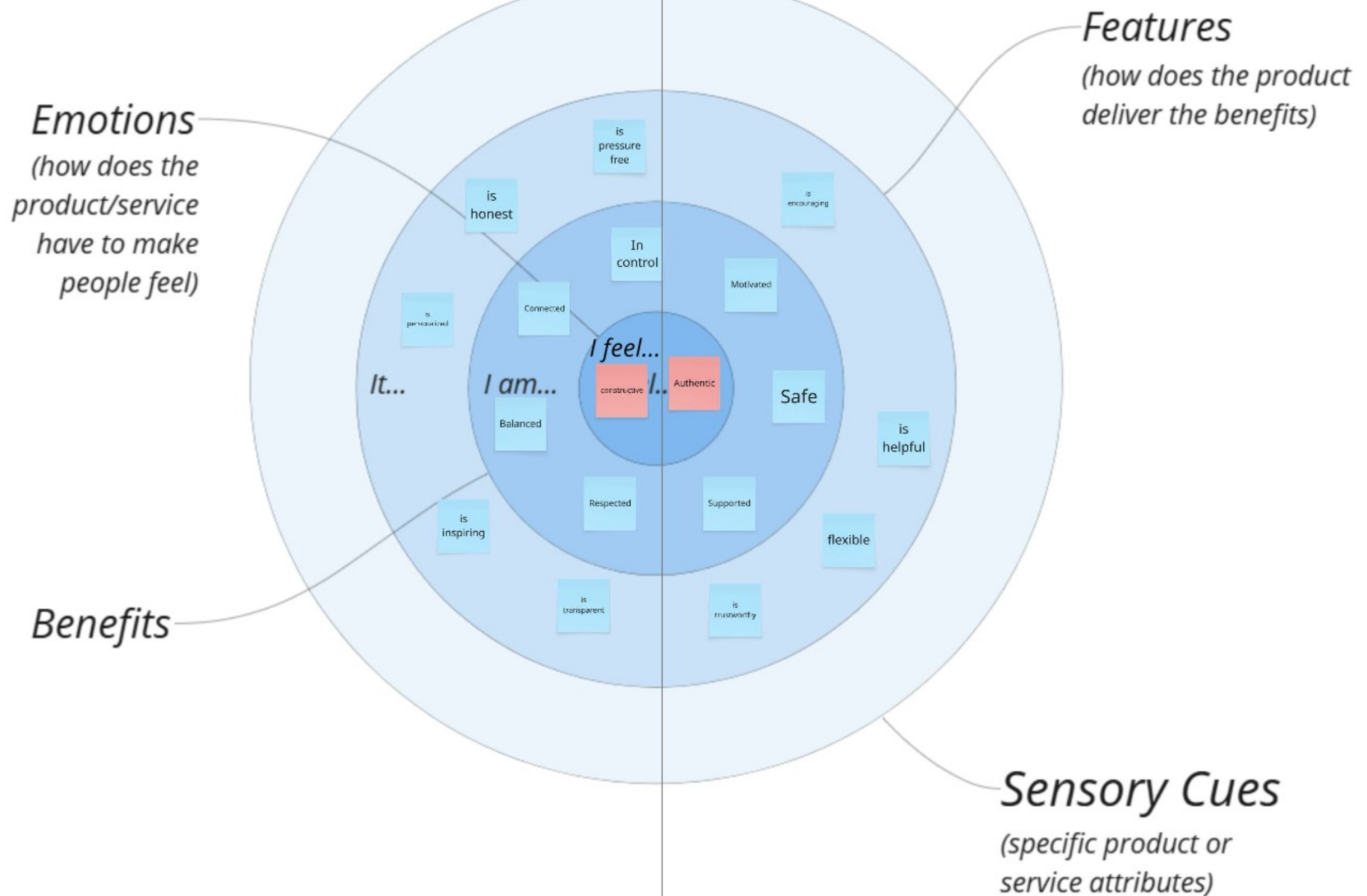
The first layer focuses on product features, or the foundational qualities users believe wellness on social media should embody. According to collected data, an ideal experience is personalized, honest, pressure free, encouraging, helpful, flexible, trustworthy, transparent, and inspiring. These features represent the visible and functional elements users expect from digital wellness spaces. They define the standards for ***what makes wellness content feel credible and supportive*** rather than performative or harmful. This layer establishes the conditions necessary for meaningful engagement.

The second layer identifies the benefits users gain when those features are successfully delivered. When wellness content aligns with these expectations, users feel balanced, respected, supported, safe, motivated, in control, and connected. These benefits represent the practical and psychological value created by a ***healthier digital wellness experience.*** Finally, the third and most important layer captures the emotional core of the ideal experience: users feel constructive and authentic. These emotions reflect the ultimate goal of wellness engagement, where ***social media becomes a space that supports genuine self development*** rather than external validation. Together, these three layers create a clear roadmap for understanding how wellness platforms can better serve users by building from trustworthy features to meaningful emotional outcomes.

The Ideal Experience Framework is a strategic tool used to transform raw user research into a clear and structured understanding of what people truly need, feel, and value. Rather than simply collecting opinions or behaviors, this framework organizes user insights into four interconnected dimensions: ***Emotions, Features, Benefits, and Sensory Cues.*** Together, these categories help reveal not only how users interact with wellness content, but also how those interactions shape their perceptions, motivations, and overall experiences. By translating lived experiences into organized patterns, the framework creates a bridge between research and actionable understanding.

For users, this process ensures that their voices, behaviors, and emotional realities are ***accurately represented*** beyond surface level trends. It captures what wellness means to them on a deeper level by identifying emotional drivers, desired features, practical benefits, and sensory influences that shape engagement. This allows researchers to move beyond scattered responses and instead uncover meaningful relationships between what users say, what they do, and what they truly need. In the context of Gen Z wellness culture, this framework helps clarify the gap between performative digital habits and authentic wellbeing practices.

For our client, the Ideal Experience Framework condenses large volumes of qualitative and behavioral data into a ***digestible web of key themes and strategic insights.*** Complex user research becomes a visual and practical system that designers, business leaders, and strategists can easily interpret and apply. This framework turns scattered findings into focused opportunities, helping our client identify where to innovate, how to better serve their audience, and how to build experiences rooted in genuine user wellbeing. Ultimately, it transforms research into strategy by making user data both ***understandable and actionable.***



Ideal Experience

1. Emotions

How does the product/service have to make people feel



I feel...
constructive

- My experience helps me grow in a healthy and realistic way.
- I receive encouragement that supports long-term wellbeing rather than pressure or comparison.
- The experience motivates positive reflection and meaningful habits.
- I feel guided toward improvement without judgment.

- I can express my wellness journey honestly without feeling the need to perform for others.
- I feel comfortable being myself instead of following unrealistic wellness standards.
- The experience reflects real life rather than curated perfection.
- I feel accepted even when my routines, habits, or progress are imperfect.



Ideal Experience

2. Benefits

What does the product/service have to provide to make
people feel this way



I am... connected

- I feel connected to others through shared experiences and encouragement.
- The experience helps create a sense of belonging and emotional support.
- I can interact with people who understand similar wellness struggles and goals.
- Wellness feels more meaningful when shared with others.



- I can manage my wellness experience in a way that fits my personal needs and boundaries.
- I decide what I share, consume, and engage with online.
- I feel empowered to shape my own routines and goals.
- The experience gives me freedom rather than pressure.



I am... in control



I am... motivated

- I feel encouraged to maintain healthy habits consistently.
- The experience inspires me to continue improving my wellbeing over time.
- I feel energized by realistic and achievable wellness goals.
- I stay engaged without feeling overwhelmed.

I am... respected

- My personal boundaries, choices, and wellness pace are acknowledged.
- I feel valued regardless of my lifestyle, habits, or progress.
- The experience avoids forcing unrealistic expectations on users.
- I feel treated as an individual rather than compared to others.





I am... safe

- I feel emotionally comfortable and free from judgment or comparison.
- I can engage with wellness content without feeling pressured or insecure.
- The environment feels supportive, respectful, and trustworthy.
- I feel protected from toxic or unrealistic wellness culture.

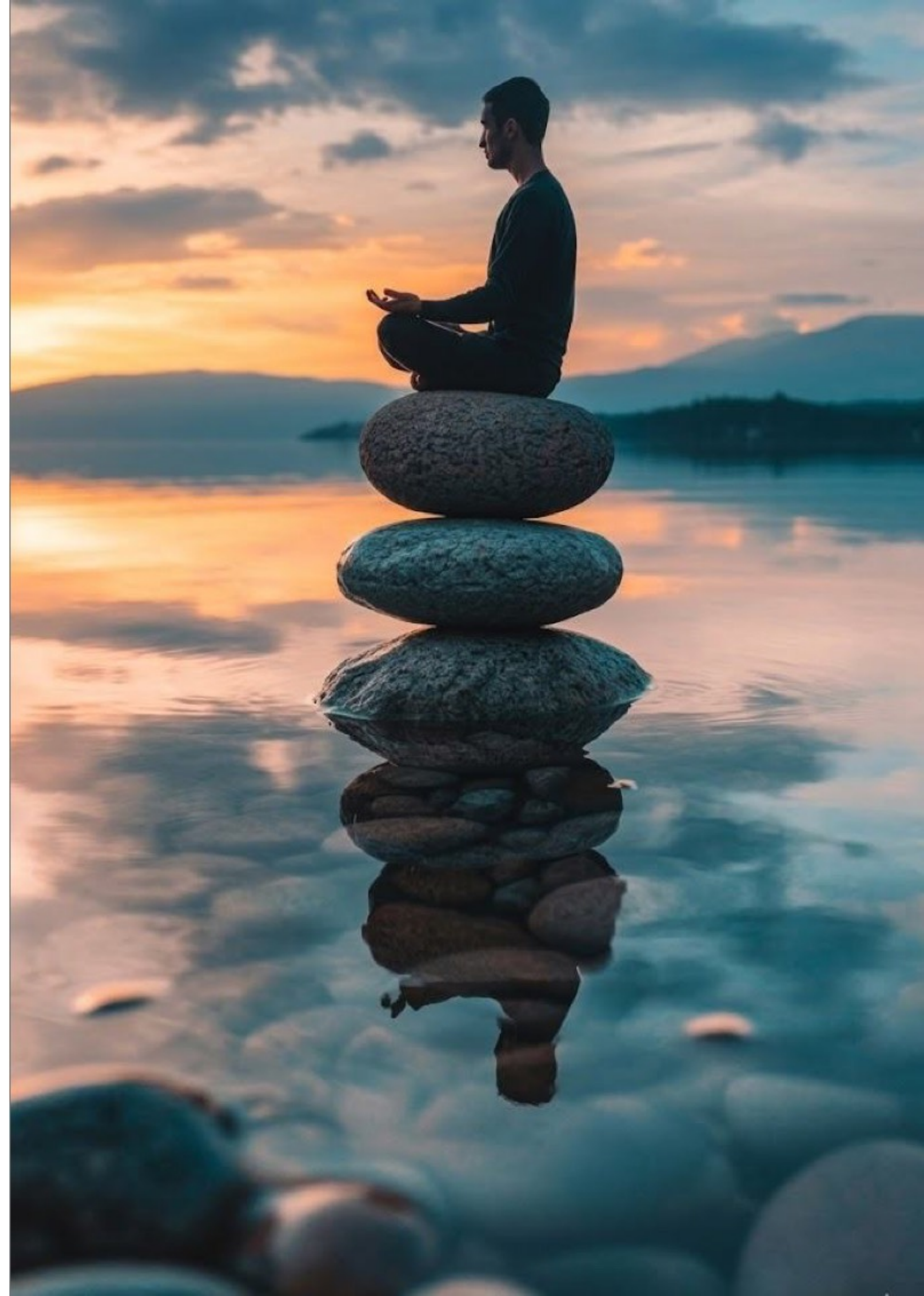
- The experience reminds me that I do not have to improve alone.
- I feel understood, reassured, and cared for by the community or platform./
- I can seek support without fear of criticism.
- I feel emotionally encouraged throughout my wellness journey.

I am... supported



I am...
balanced

- I can maintain wellness in a realistic way that fits into everyday life.
- Experience supports both mental and physical wellbeing without extremes.
- I feel able to balance productivity, rest, and personal care.
- Wellness feels sustainable rather than overwhelming.



Ideal Experience

3. Features

How does the product deliver the benefits

The Features



The Features

- The experience avoids unhealthy comparison and unrealistic expectations.
- Users can engage with wellness at their own pace.
- The environment feels calm, supportive, and non-judgmental.

It... is honest



- The platform presents wellness in a realistic and transparent way.
- Content feels genuine instead of overly curated or performative.
- Users are encouraged to share authentic experiences rather than perfection.

It... is encouraging



- The platform motivates users through positive and supportive interactions.
- Users feel inspired without feeling pressured.
- Encouragement focuses on progress rather than perfection.

It..
is helpful

- The platform provides practical support that users can apply in real life.
- Wellness advice feels useful, simple, and achievable.
- The experience helps users make steady and meaningful progress.

It..
is flexible



- Users can engage with wellness in ways that fit their schedules and lifestyles.
- The experience supports different definitions of wellness and success.
- Users can personalize how much they participate, share, or explore.

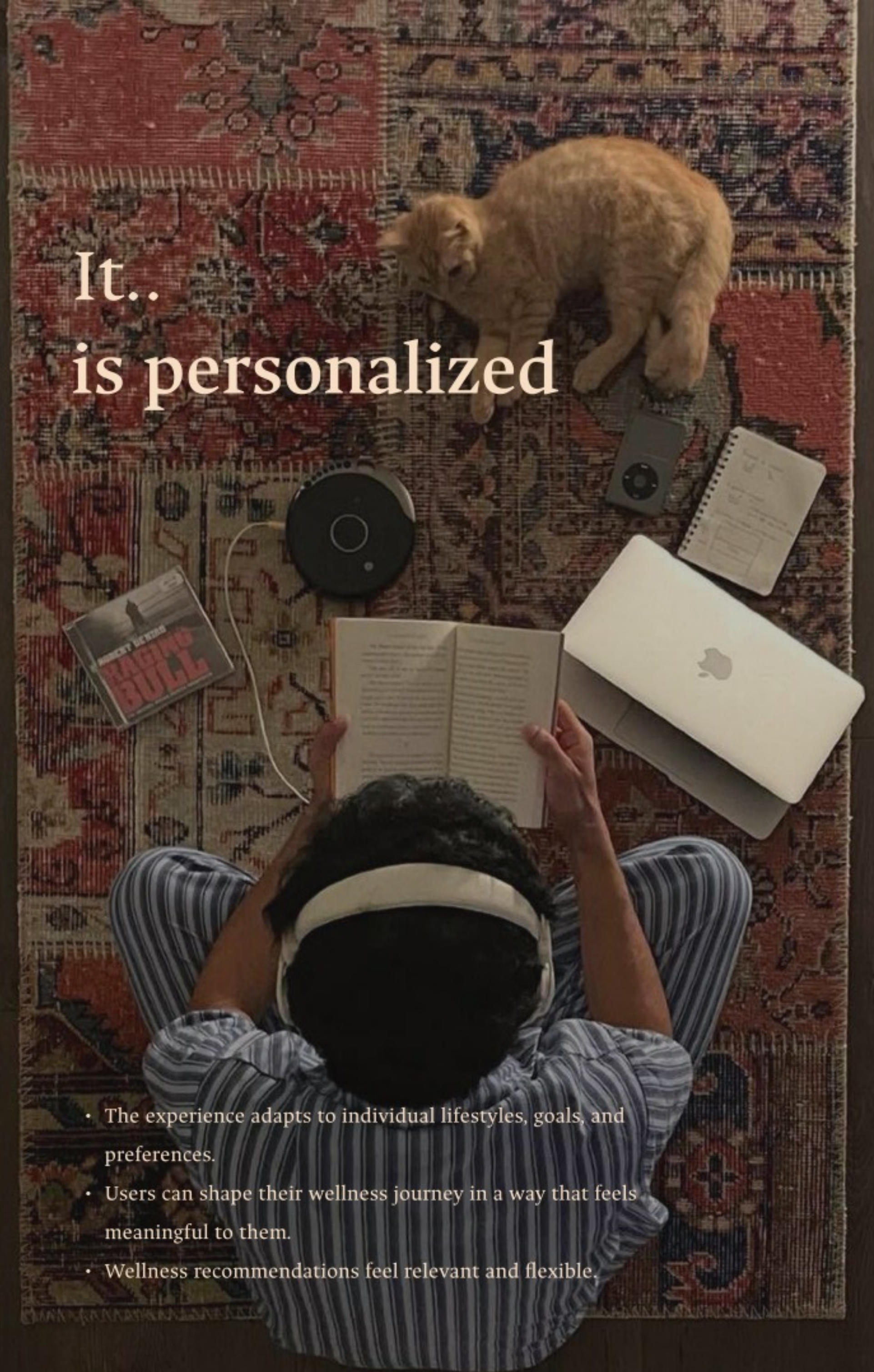
The Features



It.. is trustworthy

- Wellness content feels reliable, realistic, and evidence-based.
- Users feel confident engaging with the platform and community.
- The experience prioritizes user wellbeing over performance or trends.

It.. is personalized



- The experience adapts to individual lifestyles, goals, and preferences.
- Users can shape their wellness journey in a way that feels meaningful to them.
- Wellness recommendations feel relevant and flexible.



It..
is inspiring

- The platform encourages users to explore healthier and more fulfilling routines.
- Users feel inspired by relatable and realistic wellness experiences.
- The experience promotes creativity, growth, and self-reflection.



It...
is transparent

- Users clearly understand how content, recommendations, and interactions work.
- The platform communicates openly and honestly.
- Trust is built through clarity and authenticity.

BOOK TITLE BY AUTHOR NAME

Opportunity Areas



Private-First Wellness Companion

Wellness that doesn't need an audience.

Insight Synthesis The strongest single signal in the data is that users want wellness to be theirs. They feel uncomfortable with public wellness culture, they don't always label their own healthy habits as "wellness" (because that word has been colonized by aesthetics), and the things they actually do — skincare, art, walks, hobbies — are intimate, unphotographed, daily.

Why Now Mainstream "anti-social-media" backlash is making private, single-player digital tools culturally credible (e.g., journaling apps, single-user fitness trackers). Users are ready for tools that don't ask them to perform.

Concept Directions

- "Quiet Log" — a daily check-in app with a single-page interface, no profile, no social layer at all. Users name 3 things they did for themselves today; the app remembers patterns and reflects them back monthly.
- "My Definition" — onboarding that asks users to write their own definition of wellness in 3 sentences, and surfaces it back during use so the app's language matches theirs.
- "Offline-First Wellness" — a physical/digital hybrid (a small object, a notebook + companion app) that intentionally exists outside the social platforms.

Save-To-Act Bridge

Closing the gap between inspiration and behavior.

Insight Synthesis This is the most actionable pain point in the dataset. Users save constantly. They almost never do. Saving has replaced doing – and the unread "Saved" folder becomes a source of low-grade guilt.

Why Now The mismatch between content density and action capacity is widely felt but unaddressed. Existing apps (Notion, Pocket, IG Saves) treat saved content as a passive archive, not an action queue.

Concept Directions

- "Reel-to-Real" – a browser/app extension that lets users save a wellness video and instantly converts it into a 1-step action ("Tomorrow, 3 squats. That's it."), schedulable into their calendar.
- "Saved Folder Audit" – a periodic ritual where the app surfaces 3 old saves and asks: "Still want to try this? If yes → schedule. If no → release." The release act is celebrated, not penalized.
- "Smallest Possible Version" – for any saved routine, the app generates a 60-second version of it. Users build up only if they want to.

Algorithmic Self-Curation

Giving users the steering wheel of their own feed.

Insight Synthesis Users are acutely aware that algorithms shape what they see, and that this shapes how they feel. They already perform makeshift interventions – unfollowing, muting, switching apps, going on detoxes. But these tools are blunt. The platform's curation logic is opaque and optimized for engagement, not wellbeing.

Why Now Regulatory and cultural pressure on algorithmic transparency is rising. Users now expect – not just hope for – controls over what platforms feed them.

Concept Directions

- "Feed Thermostat" – a global slider per topic: "Less aspirational More practical." Adjusts what the algorithm surfaces in real time.
- "Tone Filters" – opt-in filters like no before/after photos, no body-focused content, no commercial wellness, applied across platforms via a unified layer (browser extension or OS-level).
- "Mood-Aware Pacing" – a daily check-in: "How are you feeling today?" → if low, the feed deprioritizes comparison-heavy content.

Credibility & Trust Signals

Surfacing genuine expertise in a sea of aesthetic.

Insight Synthesis Users are not credulous. They have a clear, articulated trust hierarchy: real expertise > friends > strangers with aesthetic feeds > overt advertisements. The problem is that platforms flatten this hierarchy – a dermatologist and a 19-year-old promoting a sponsored serum get rendered with identical visual weight.

Why Now Misinformation in health/wellness is a recognized public health issue. Platform-level credibility infrastructure is overdue.

Concept Directions

- "Credibility Layer" – an overlay on wellness content showing: creator's professional verification status, commercial relationships, citations. Optional but persistent.
- "Trusted Circle Feed" – a separate feed surface populated only by content your chosen 5–10 trusted people engaged with.
- "Receipts Mode" – a toggle that hides all content without verifiable sourcing. Strict; for users who want a high-trust environment.

Imperfect Wellness Normalization

Designing for the real, not the rendered.

Insight Synthesis The performance treadmill has eaten authenticity. Users see only curated versions of wellness; their own messy reality feels inadequate by comparison. Some users have already invented their own coping strategy: sharing wellness casually, indirectly, or through humor – never seriously, never aspirationally.

Why Now Gen Z is already pushing back against polished aesthetics (BeReal, photo dumps, "ugly" selfies). A wellness application of this cultural shift is overdue.

Concept Directions

- "Wellness BeReal" – a once-a-day prompt to capture whatever wellness-adjacent thing you did, no edits, low quality, friends-only.
- "Attempt Cards" – a sharing format whose template is literally "I tried [x]. It [went / didn't go]. Next time I'll [y]." Structurally cannot become an aspirational post.
- "Wellness Memes" – a built-in template library for humorous, self-deprecating wellness moments. Lowers the stakes of sharing.

Mental Wellbeing Guardrails

Active protection from the harms of the medium.

Insight Synthesis Users are already practicing self-protection: unfollowing, muting, taking breaks, distancing themselves from trends. They want the platform to do more of this work for them – to be a partner in protecting their mental health, not an adversary.

Why Now Platforms are increasingly under legal and reputational pressure to demonstrate harm mitigation. There is a market and a mandate for wellbeing tooling that actually works.

Concept Directions

- "Consumption Mood Check" – after every 15 minutes of wellness content, a 2-second prompt: "How does this feel?" The aggregate data trains personalized filters.
- "Comparison Tax Report" – a weekly summary showing what kinds of content correlate with worse-mood check-ins. Pure information, no prescriptions.
- "Soft Off-Ramp" – when consumption patterns predict negative emotion, the feed gently transitions to non-wellness content (nature, animals, art).

Ideal Outcome

The ideal outcome of this research is a digital wellness experience that helps Gen Z build a healthier relationship with both social media and themselves. Rather than feeling pressured to perform wellness for an audience, users would engage with content that supports their personal goals, lifestyles, and definitions of wellbeing. Wellness would no longer be measured through aesthetics, productivity, or online validation, but through meaningful habits, self awareness, balance, and genuine personal growth.

According to our Ideal Experience Framework, this outcome is achieved when wellness content is honest, pressure free, encouraging, helpful, flexible, trustworthy, transparent, inspiring, and personalized to individual needs. When these qualities are present, users are more likely to feel balanced, respected, supported, safe, motivated, in control, and connected. These benefits create an environment where wellness becomes accessible and sustainable rather than overwhelming or performative.

At its core, the ideal outcome is an experience that feels constructive and authentic. Users can engage with wellness content without comparison, guilt, or unrealistic expectations. Instead, social media becomes a tool that encourages healthy behaviors, supports self improvement, and empowers individuals to define wellness on their own terms. This vision serves as the foundation for future design opportunities, content strategies, and digital experiences that better support the wellbeing of Gen Z audiences.

Social Impact

The findings from this research have implications beyond individual wellness experiences and reveal how social media shapes broader cultural perceptions of health, success, and self worth among Gen Z. As wellness content continues to grow across platforms, it has the power to influence behaviors, attitudes, and expectations on a large scale. However, when wellness is presented through unrealistic routines, carefully curated lifestyles, or constant self optimization, it can contribute to comparison, pressure, and feelings of inadequacy. Understanding these influences is essential for creating healthier digital environments.

By identifying what Gen Z values in authentic wellness content, this research provides insight into how creators, brands, platforms, and designers can better support positive wellbeing online. Promoting transparency, realistic self care practices, diverse experiences, and achievable habits can help shift wellness culture away from performance and toward genuine support. These changes encourage users to engage with wellness in ways that feel relevant, attainable, and personally meaningful rather than dictated by social expectations or online trends.

Ultimately, the social impact of this research lies in its potential to foster healthier digital communities. When wellness content prioritizes authenticity, users are more likely to feel supported, connected, respected, and empowered in their everyday lives. By encouraging more honest conversations about wellbeing and reducing the pressure to present a perfect lifestyle, this research contributes to a social media landscape that promotes mental wellbeing, strengthens social connection, and supports a more inclusive understanding of what it means to be well.

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